

The Radical Imagination: On a Parallel between Imagination and Judgment in the Kantian System

My exposition on imagination in Kant is motivated by what I consider can be inferred from the transcendental system, based on a reading of the *Critique of Judgment*. In particular, with regard to the difference, analyzed above all in the "First Introduction" to the Third Critique, between the function of the reflective judgment and the function of the determinant judgment. The first comprising the encyclopedic perspective of the system and the second, he alone, recognizable within the limits of the doctrinal concept of philosophy. Kant tells us clearly that although the *Urteilkraft* may have "its own a priori principles", which, perhaps, underpin "a special part of philosophy", even so, philosophy, "as a system, can only be bipartite": strictly speaking, there are only theoretical and practical philosophy.

My idea is, roughly speaking, that Imagination [*Einbildungskraft*], as much as heautonomous *Urteilkraft*, it plays an ambiguous role in a system whose critical performance seems to require a propaedeutic outcome: In other words, determining a possible legality, that is, of an objectivity legitimable for the philosophical use of thought. Schiller, who declares himself a Kantian within the context of the first two critiques, complains, on the Third, precisely that lack of positive instruction that, obtained through overcoming the subjectivity of judgments of taste, would equate Kant's three main works, which would make the system tripartite. But this comes at a cost: The Kantian emphasis on "judgment" (*Urteil*) – which is classical – is shifted to the object. An object that, albeit only from an aesthetic perspective, acquires autonomy.

Furthermore, I want to say, beyond this mirroring between Imagination and Judgment, which, I think, reflects a functional ambiguity of those faculties in the transcendental system, I tried to take into consideration my advisor's doctoral thesis, Rubens Torres Filho, of USP, and titled *The Spirit and the Letter*, and which, according to the subtitle, is a "Critique of Pure Imagination

in Fichte". A careful essay that begins with Fichte's assertion that every operation performed by the human spirit originates in the imagination. A statement I understand, reflecting on the first page of Aristotle's *Metaphysics*, as if to say: Imagination—*phantasia* for the Greeks—lies at the origin of the spirit: it is the nascent spirit, albeit not self-conscious and self-regulated.

The truth is that, in Aristotle, *phantasia*, being the medium through which the differences offered by the senses, above all through vision, are concatenated, it posits itself as a *conditio sine qua non* condition of *empeiria*. And *empeiria*, which presupposes the power to perform concatenation, it is nothing more than the first form of unity through which thought asserts itself as an activity, thus, as spontaneity. A unity very similar to the one Kant speaks of in § 10 of the Transcendental Analytic, and which, despite being blind, performs the function of synthesis of the "multiple of pure intuition". A synthesis that is free of the commitments – that is, the legal or formal obligations – that are gradually being agreed upon in increasingly higher and more comprehensive stages of connection achieved through thought, as they are in cognition through *téchne*, *epistème*, and philosophical *sophia*, according to the framework Aristotle offers us.

What matters in the end is that there is no concatenation of the singular data of the senses (*aistheseis*) without *phantasia*, without imagination. According to what Aristotle presents to us, it would be through the emergence of *phantasia* in man that we distinguish ourselves from so-called irrational animals, creating the conditions for "evolution", for the progressive and disciplined self-understanding of the spirit.

Perhaps the simplest way to get straight to the point of my presentation is to recall that Kant, in the Preface to the first edition of the *Critique of Pure Reason*, after discussing the importance of the transcendental deduction of categories, tells us that his intention, in this specific work, it is not to explain "how the faculty of thinking itself is possible (*das Vermögen zu Denken*) – pure

and simple –, but the conditions for a very specific use of the same, that is, of the use of our Understanding (*Verstand*) (A XVII). Kant was occupied with the question concerning the possible scientific status of metaphysics. In any case, it is one thing to investigate the nature of thought in general, another thing is knowing how to apply it with discipline (method) to a specific type of object, to the phenomenon.

The synthesis of this difference can be found in § 22 of the *Analytics*, which begins with the statement that: “To think an object and to know an object is not (...) the same thing” (B 146). For example, in reflective judgment, we think of an object (the beautiful), but no cognition results from this. In this case, we have the formal structuring of thought or judgment without a guiding rule being identified for the conduct of the reflective action.

Thinking of an object without having a concept for it leads Kant to diagnose such thought as blind, so it is the same blindness recognized in the “general synthesis” of Imagination, a function, Kant tells us, so “indispensable to the soul” that without it “we would have no knowledge whatsoever” (KrV, § 10). What has been said so far is this: without the Understanding [*Verstand*], as a subspecies of thought [*das Denken*], we wouldn't have science, just as without “the simple effect of the capacity of Imagination”, we would not evolve to the point of converting thought into effective cognition.

What, then, is the difference between simple thought and imagination? Why does Kant, when addressing the discursive nature of thought in relation to sensible intuition and thus prepare ourselves for the logical framework of the concepts, equates the acts of the judgment to the understanding in general, to the faculty of judging and the faculty of thinking, however, it says nothing about Imagination, if she satisfies what is sought through these names? That's because the central point here is to give unity to our representations, it is having the capacity for synthesis, a predicate that is inherent to the imagination and establishes its action.

The answer here is that, within the framework of the eminently epistemic debate in which the first critique is situated: „Thought is knowledge by means of concepts” (B 94); a claim absent not only from the judgment of reflection (non-determinative), but, and above all, to the Imagination, termed “blind”.

What qualifies thought to “suspend” the natural indeterminacy of phenomena (*Erscheinungen*) – which are mere appearances –, giving them a meaning, it is the power that it (thought) acquires, due to our need to reach a consensus on the nature of things. A power, I would say, not just to gather, but, literally, to formally confine intuitive data within classes of objects. And this requires a degree of intentionality and abstraction that thought does not possess, or did not have—as a conscious obligation—at its origin; that is, when it was still merely thought (*das Denken*), without imposing upon itself the search for an agreement within the understanding (*Verstand*).

In the history of philosophy outlined in the Logic manual, Kant describes the transition from the ordinary use of thought (understanding *latu sensu*) to the speculation characteristic of philosophical rationality as a shift of “knowledge of the universal *in concreto*”, by trial (*Versuchen*), to the knowledge of the universal *in abstracto* (Ak 27). It is the need to find some consistency and internal coherence which leads thought to organize itself and gradually self-regulate – organization that comes about, obviously, through trial and error (*Versuchen*).

I am very interested in understanding this “trial” (*Versuche*), as being that reflective effort, even if pre-logical or pre-conceptual, recognized in the *Überlegung* conducted by the reflective judgment, of which the third Critique speaks. And we can say, until proven otherwise, that we are talking about the same case observed in the relationship between grammar and language (*Sprache*) in general. As Kant asserts, whoever speaks a language without knowing the grammar “it truly possesses a grammar and speaks according to rules of which, however, it is not conscious” (*Lógica*, AK 11).

Kant considers that there is a non-evident presupposition, a maxim, at the base of all structuring of thought and the way we use language, both to represent things in our minds and to communicate them. That is why he can assert in his manual of logic: “All of nature in general is, in fact, nothing more than the connection of phenomena according to rules” (Ak 11). In 1790, this will serve to justify the need for an exclusive principle for heautonomous *Urteilkraft*. A principle without which thought, however casual, it would not be activated. Because it exists by connecting representations, it exists insofar as it seeks a predicate for an object, whatever that object may be. A search pursued at any cost – in mere reflection. An action of the spirit that, even without a predetermined rule, It requires recognition of its necessity. In other words, it requires the negation of *Regellosigkeit*, from the absence of rules in the world—including in thought.

What distinguishes the synthesis of the faculty of reflective judgment (*reflectierende Urteilkraft*) of the synthesis of Imagination (*Einbildungskraft*), both in a predetermined situation or condition, or rather, not a determinant of thought, in the case of *Urteilkraft*, it appears to be the consciousness acquired through the continuous act of comparing (*Überlegen*), that there is a logical, yet unfilled, space of the concept (*Begriff*). *Facultas dijudicandi*, says the text of the First Introduction, compares and interconnects representations “with a concept in view” that reflection itself makes possible. Unlike what occurs in the determinant mode of judgment characteristic of the understanding, in which the concept, previously merely possible, is already real and objectively functional.

I called, in a text written in Halle, *Urteilkraft* of “wild thought”, distinguishing it from “civilized” thinking, in the sense of being obedient to rules. Rules that, as Kant says, reason gives to itself, for it is reason itself that institutes them. It is as if the limitation of the use of thought by means of the laws of the Understanding and Reason remove thought from its natural state. And what is this condition? Simple reflection, which, belatedly, finds itself subject to the rules imposed by categories and ideas.

The point I would like to make is that, within the transcendental system, what triggers the originary activity that founds the spirit, as Fichte says, which gives life to the soul, It appears to be the same, whether it is a matter of the blind imagination or of the **Urteilkraft** without a concept. I suspect that we can, even while taking great care, to place the synthesis function of one faculty in the place of another, without significantly altering the overall picture outlined by Kant, since, in any case, the philosophical system is the system of the understanding and the system of reason combined.

But what unites these two systems, the passage from one to the other, the *Übergang*, is, by nature, “pre-systematic” or merely encyclopedic. With this, we must accept the fact that it creates the subjective conditions of the system, sketches out the work, but remains outside the doctrinal edifice, since *Urteilkraft*, like the Imagination, is capable only of an indeterminate synthesis. The world represented by Imagination and the faculty of judgment It's an always-open system, like nature itself in general – living nature.

Imagination and Judgment (*Urteilkraft*) remain the primitive elements of the spirit. In fact, they constitute the basis for its possibility. The two faculties have before them more than a mere aggregate of things. They have a conglomerate of them; after all, these things are all mixed up together. The late emergence of understanding and reason makes our perceptions of the multiplicity of intuition, originally, a chaotic apprehension, the verification of a contingent whole for which the faculty of judgment seeks a provisional and merely subjective lawfulness. The object of the aesthetic reflective judgment, for example, It is perceived as a singularity that the *Urteilkraft* attempts to accommodate in a universality that he does not respect and that overflows. And despite that, she follows her spontaneity and always seeks this synthesis, even if in vain.

If we consider Imagination, we have something similar, because if the synthesis produced by her aimed at singular intuition, then this would result in the image of a single object, represented in isolation. This would prevent

Imagination from collaborating with the understanding in the cognitive process. However, productive and pure Imagination goes far beyond capturing singularity in the context of Kant's thought.

While on the one hand we quickly associate imagination (*imaginatio*) and image (*imago*), The doctrine of schematism shows us that *Einbildungskraft* is the formal condition of the image, therefore, it plays an organizing role. The scheme is what makes the image possible, it cannot be confused with it. The scheme is eminently intellectual in nature, the image, on the other hand, is intuitive.

Ultimately, my intention in all this was not to offer a definitive statement regarding what I termed the ambiguous condition of Imagination and Judgment (*Urteilkraft*) in the transcendental system. My main intention was to show that it is possible to do, as I said, a mirroring between these two faculties, at once fundamental and almost secondary in light of the doctrinal concept of philosophy proposed by Kant.

What matters most to me, then even without having a ready made solution to this question? What matters is that it gives us plenty to think about.